

Greek theatre, electric lights, and the plumes of locomotives: the quarrel between the Futurists and the Classicists and the Hellenic modernism of Fascism

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Abstract

The controversy between the Futurists and the classicists over the Greek theatre of Syracuse remains largely overlooked within the scholarship concerned with the relationship between Futurism and Fascism. The Futurist movement launched a polemic against the staging of Aeschylus' *Libation Bearers* in 1921, counterposing Greek tragedy to new forms of drama drawing on Futurist performance aesthetics and Sicilian popular theatre which, according to the Futurists, could express the spirit of the modern age. In a similar vein, the manifesto that F. T. Marinetti addressed to the Fascist government in 1923 advocated for the staging of modern Sicilian plays in the theatre of Syracuse. Contrary to Futurism, Italian Fascism turned to Greek models in creating new forms of popular theatre. Mussolini's state supported the production of ancient drama throughout the *ventennio*, as evidenced by the consolidation of the *Istituto Nazionale del Dramma Antico* (INDA) in 1925. The theatre of Syracuse should be viewed as a field of antagonism between the different versions of modernism represented by Futurism and Fascism. By examining the convergences and divergences of Futurist and Fascist visions of theatrical renewal, this article highlights not only the Hellenic character of Fascism's modernism but also the role of Fascism in transforming classical traditions.

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On 13 May 1924 Mussolini arrived in Syracuse on a seaplane to attend the double-bill performance of Aeschylus' *Seven against Thebes* and Sophocles' *Antigone* which marked the fourth cycle of the festival organized at the ancient Greek theatre by

the *Comitato per le Rappresentazioni Classiche* (Committee for the Classical Performances) (Figure 1).¹ The president of the Committee, Count Mario Tommaso Gargallo, together with a delegation of members and local officials, had visited Mussolini in January to extend an invitation to that year's festival.² Mussolini's attendance at the festival occurred during his first visit to Sicily as head of government, in a bid to bring the island into the fold of Fascism. According to the programme published in the press, his itinerary included the inauguration of the new roads and the laying of the foundation stone for the garden city Mussolinia.³ For all Mussolini's lofty rhetoric about leading Sicily into a new era of progress, it is well known that the industrial and structural reforms promised to the Sicilian people did not go far enough, whilst the construction of Mussolinia was not completed.⁴ The political importance of Mussolini's visit should rather be sought in its symbolic and cultural significance. Apart from visiting different locations to view local problems at first hand, Mussolini would lay a wreath at the Memorial of the Expedition of the Thousand, which commemorated the campaign of the Risorgimento that resulted in the unification of north and south, unveil a WW1 monument in Ragusa, and inspect the *Milizia Nazionale della Sicilia* (National Militia of Sicily).⁵ In Syracuse, he would visit an air base and meet, among others, fascist organizations as well as war veterans, invalids, and orphans.⁶



Figure 1. 'The crowd attending the performance in honour of His Excellency B. Mussolini', 1924 (source: Archivio Fondazione INDA, Rassegna Stampa 1924, courtesy of INDA).

The visit to Syracuse that concluded Mussolini's Sicilian tour demonstrated the Regime's support for the Committee's efforts to bring back performances at the

Greek theatre. As confirmed in a telegram addressed to the citizens of Syracuse, Mussolini's presence at the theatre was meant to lend importance and encouragement to the Committee's undertaking,⁷ but the cultural impact of his visit to Syracuse extended beyond his attendance at the classical performances. The press saluted the naval presence at the city's port — gateway to Italy's colonies in Africa and the Mediterranean — whilst referring to the modern means of transport used during Mussolini's journey: seaplanes, trains, ships, submarines, and 'roaring cars'.⁸ After his departure from Syracuse aboard the battleship *Dante Alighieri*, his message to the Sicilian people was aired on the radio.⁹ Although materially Sicily fell short of Fascism's modernization of the country, it was symbolically included in the process of national reconstruction. The mechanical age embraced by the Regime stood for the unity of centre and periphery, enabling Mussolini to reach out to the Sicilian people and to fuse the ancient past, the Fascist present, and the vision of a future *imperium*.

In both Fascist Italy and Nazi Germany, the deployment of modern technology played a key role in ushering in a new era. As a modernist phenomenon, interwar fascism did not merely enable a symbiosis between technology and tradition but merged the two in producing a mythicized version of modernity. These modernist tendencies can be witnessed in the opening scenes of Leni Riefenstahl's *Triumph of the Will* (1935), where Hitler arrives by aeroplane in Nuremberg to attend the Sixth Congress of the Nazi Party. Riefenstahl's camerawork alternates shots of the aeroplane — in part or in its entirety — with aerial shots of the city and its historic buildings, the marching crowds, and images of the skies through a romanticizing gaze that interweaves history, nature, and technology into a single aesthetic vision. A similar intertwining of technology with tradition characterized Mussolini's public appearances during which air shows occurred above historic sites. As historian Emilio Gentile notes, these shows 'introduced an element of modernity into the setting of monuments from Italy's past'.¹⁰ The Regime's interest in the performances at the Greek theatre of Syracuse can therefore be seen as pivotal to the process of assimilating classical antiquity — including Sicily's Hellenic past — into Italian Fascism's project of modernization.

However, for the artistic vanguard the classical performances at Syracuse represented an antiquarianism which was at odds with the programme of modernizing Italian culture. In 1921, the Futurists in Sicily opposed the staging of Aeschylus' *Libation Bearers*; their reaction was in line with the movement's fervid rejection of classical art as part of a stultifying tradition. Yet it is worth noting that the Sicilian Futurists were not averse to the idea of using the theatre of Syracuse. Instead, in a rare instance of Futurism showing an interest in classical ruins, they presented a plan for staging modern plays there. Their proposals were disseminated in different variations, which continued to circulate until 1924 and

even resurfaced in the thirties and during WW2, without ever coming to fruition. Meanwhile, the state promoted forms of popular and mass theatre to reach out to large audiences. The travelling theatres known as *Carri di Tespi* (Thespian Cars), which were developed in the late twenties, offered open-air performances in public spaces in cities and towns all over Italy with the aim of making operatic and dramatic works available to wider audiences.¹¹ The support granted to the classical performances should be understood more in relation to Italian Fascism's efforts to popularize high art rather than an adherence to classical tradition. Along these lines, the Syracusan Committee was upgraded to a national organization in 1925, and renamed the *Istituto Nazionale del Dramma Antico* (INDA). After attending the classical performances in 1924, Mussolini was reported as saying that the theatre of Syracuse should host stagings of modern plays alongside Greek and Roman drama.¹² Yet throughout the *ventennio* INDA's focus remained on Greek drama and spectacles inspired by classical antiquity, with just a few exceptions of stagings of Roman plays.¹³ Following the 'fascistization' of INDA in the late twenties, its efforts to bring ancient drama to larger audiences assumed a more conspicuously nationalistic character.

Like Futurism, Fascism worshipped technology and promoted the idea of art as the expression of a new age. The question then arises as to why Mussolini's state turned to classical theatre rather than adopting the radical plans of the Futurist movement in developing new forms of popular theatre. To understand these interconnections between Futurism, classicism, and Fascism, I will first focus on the polemic launched by the exponents of Futurism against the performances of Greek drama at Syracuse and their alternative proposals for the use of the ancient theatre. Their vehement reaction will be viewed not merely in terms of conflicting aesthetic ideals but as a rivalry over the reform of the theatre under Italian Fascism. The analysis points at the commonalities between Futurist theatres and classical performances to foreground their intersecting visions of renewing theatrical aesthetics. Although Greek theatre provided a site of antagonism between Futurism and classicism, close examination of the competing theatrical models they represented can demonstrate that beneath their diversity lay a common urge to reinvent modernity. The final section of this article discusses the controversy surrounding the relationship between Fascism and Futurism after Mussolini's rise to power. In light of that debate, I venture an appraisal of the role of classicism in shaping Fascist modernism. The invocation of the classical past on the one hand, and the cult of the machine on the other, can both be understood as attempts to restore a mythical energy to the modern world. In that sense, I argue, far from venerating classical tradition, Fascism's turn to Greek theatre was underpinned by an urge to recreate the world, which also spurred Futurist

experimentation. Yet in the case of Futurism, this urge entailed an assault on classical tradition.

‘The dead are killing those who live’

Although Italian Fascism aligned with Futurism in viewing art as a vehicle for transforming reality, the two movements displayed a different stance towards the classical tradition. For Fascism, classical art was a force for spiritual renewal, whereas for Futurism it represented an ossified canon that the vanguard of young artists should wipe out. The anti-classical fervour that had characterized Futurism since its early days resurfaced in the form of a full-blown assault on the stagings of Greek drama at Syracuse.

In spring 1921, following a break due to WW1, the Committee for the Classical Performances resumed staging Greek drama at the theatre of Syracuse with a production of Aeschylus’ *Libation Bearers*. The choice of the second play of the *Oresteia* underscored the continuity with the 1914 *Agamemnon* which had marked the first use of the ancient theatre in the modern era. In the days leading up to the opening night, the Futurists instigated a revolt against the performance culminating in the distribution of a manifesto in the theatre. The published version of this text was signed by members of the Futurist movement in Sicily.¹⁴ It is telling that the authors borrowed their epigraph from line 886 of Aeschylus’ text, where Orestes is preparing to kill Clytemnestra and Aegisthus and the servant exclaims: ‘*Dico che i morti uccidono chi vive!*’ (‘The dead are killing those who live, I tell you!’).¹⁵ In the profane language typical of Futurist texts, the authors scorned the tragic plot and characters, maintaining that the stories of Greek antiquity held no relevance for modern audiences. Furthermore, they accused the translator and coordinator of the performances, Ettore Romagnoli, of being a ‘*passatista*’ (‘passéist’) who was out of touch with the spirit of the island and the rhythm of the modern world. In the Futurists’ view, the creativity of contemporary Italians could find a better expression in either Futuristic Synthesis¹⁶ or Sicilian puppet theatre. The authors made a plea to the people of Sicily, Italy, and further afield to disregard the classical performances and walk away from the theatre: ‘*a lasciare che l’erba cresca come utile pascolo alle pecore, tra i ruderi*’ (‘to let the grass grow among the ruins as a useful pasture for the sheep’). For the Futurists, the theatre of Syracuse was nothing more than the remains of a bygone past belonging to nature rather than modern culture. Echoing Marinetti’s 1909 founding manifesto of Futurism,¹⁷ the closing lines urged intelligent spectators to join the movement in protesting against Romagnoli: ‘*Abbasso l’Arte*

Greca! Viva l'Arte Popolare Siciliana! ('Down with Greek Art! Long Live Popular Sicilian Art!').

The opening night of the *Libation Bearers* was treated by the Sicilian Futurists as an opportunity to launch a campaign against the classical performances. To this end, they invited Marinetti to participate in a motion against the 'eschylomania' ('frenzy for Aeschylus').¹⁸ Clearly, Marinetti was sufficiently invested in the cause to travel to Sicily from Sardinia, where he had been for a series of lectures. On 18 April he arrived in Syracuse and was joined by other members of the movement in Sicily. His presence must have caused turmoil as the Futurists were notorious for disrupting theatrical performances, especially operas, to distribute manifestos and propagate their aesthetic and political ideals. Amidst rumours that Marinetti intended to lead an attack on the Classicists on the opening night, he did not show up at the ancient theatre, but instead delivered a talk at the café Archimede. The anti-classical campaign continued with Marinetti's talk at the Teatro Epicarmo on the following day, which was also delivered in Catania, Messina, and Palermo over a period of five days. After leaving Sicily for Paris, he launched from Milan a manifesto presenting specific proposals for the use of the ancient theatre of Syracuse.¹⁹ The accounts provided by members of the movement should be treated with caution, given the Futurists' tendency to engineer theatrical scandals and to exaggerate the impact of their interventions.²⁰ There is evidence suggesting that there was no actual feud with the Classicists; Marinetti was among a small circle of intellectuals, politicians, and artists who attended the private performance of the Greek actress Marika Kotopouli at the Greek theatre organized by the Committee the day after the premiere of the *Libation Bearers*. On that occasion, Marinetti and Romagnoli posed for a photograph next to each other (Figure 2).²¹



Figure 2. Left to right: Ettore Romagnoli and F. T. Marinetti in the Greek Theatre of Syracuse in 1921 (source: newspaper *Πολιτεία*, 27 April 1921, 3 in Hellenic Parliament Library).

What can be gleaned from the sources is that whilst some Futurists had little interest in the Greek theatre, others saw the potential of using it to stage contemporary drama in the open air. A newspaper article by Francesco Carrozza published the following January offers an insight into the dissent within the movement. Carrozza stressed that Futurism should not merely decry the performances of Greek drama but rather present a concrete plan about the use of the ancient theatre. According to the article, the proposals put forward by Marinetti involved the organization of an annual contest of modern drama drawing on Sicilian folk theatre. The contest was meant to give young playwrights the opportunity to have their plays staged at the ancient theatre alongside the performances of ancient drama. These proposals generated debate outside Futurist circles; the Messina-based newspaper *L'Imparziale* (*The Impartial*) called a 'referendum' asking scholars to assess the viability of the Futurists' plans for the use of the ancient theatre.

The ideas discussed in Carrozza's article had already been presented in a second manifesto that appeared in Messina on 11 June under the title 'Utilizziamo

l'anfiteatro di Siracusa' ('Let's Use the Amphitheatre of Syracuse').²² This time the text was signed by a larger group of members representing different Sicilian cities, and their stance was somewhat mollified.²³ It is uncertain what caused this change of attitude within the few months since the first manifesto, but it is plausible that the favourable reception of the *Libation Bearers* forced the Futurists to adopt a more moderate approach towards the Committee, presumably to ensure that they would be allowed to use the theatre.

The second manifesto deplored the classical performances as '*esumazioni*' ('exhumations'), but it accepted them as a necessary evil whilst applauding the Committee for its initiatives that had breathed new life into the city. Rather than pleading for leaving the ancient ruins to nature, as before, they expressed an interest in performing at the theatre of Syracuse; alongside Aeschylus, they proposed staging Sicilian dramas suitable for open-air performance on an annual basis, drawing on puppet theatre as well as on religious and festive rituals which would appeal to the local populace. Apart from celebrating Sicilian tradition, this text made a larger call to the country to muster energy and funds to assist young Italian creators. The authors asserted that, despite the Committee's intentions to attract an international audience, the performance of the *Libation Bearers* was predominantly attended by locals. The Futurists advocated for a turn towards folk tradition rather than Greek antiquity in promoting a form of artistic expression that would be organically bound with Sicilian life.²⁴ Despite the reconciliatory character of their second manifesto, they made a strong case against what they perceived as dead Hellenism in favour of a theatre injected with the spirit of modernity. Their urge to prioritize modern dramatists over the classics was directly linked to Italy's modernization since its emergence from WW1. This is evident in the way this second manifesto described the environment around the theatre as '*ben poco ellenico*' ('having little to do with Hellenism') and reimagined it according to Futurist sensibilities as '*vivo, moderno, riassuntivo e dinamico*' ('alive, modern, synoptic, and dynamic').²⁵

The manifesto conjured up the standard metaphors that the movement used in denoting the advent of a new era, describing the area around the theatre as encompassing not only 'lush hills, colourful carts, sea, sails, clouds, and stars, but also electric lights of railway stations, whistles and plumes of locomotives'.²⁶

There is certainly some irony in these statements considering that, to a large extent, the infrastructures of Syracuse had been upgraded at the Committee's request in order to modernize the city for visitors and to facilitate access to the theatre.²⁷ Furthermore, the Committee saw its mission as turning the classical works into material for the modern stage. In response to the Futurists' plans, a text by Vicre (Vincenzo Cremona) published in the Committee's bulletin in 1922 addressed the contradiction in the Futurists' willingness to collaborate with those

working on the classical performances.²⁸ Vicre also defended the Committee from the accusations of ‘passéism’, emphasizing its stated intentions to use classical theatre as a means to nurture modern art.

The Futurists offered a more detailed presentation of their vision for the Greek theatre in *La Balza Futurista*, a biweekly magazine founded in Messina in 1915. The magazine was discontinued after only three volumes, but Jannelli and Nicastro published two editions exclusively dedicated to the question of the Greek theatre in January 1922 and April 1924. The 1922 edition presented the debates that surrounded their second manifesto, whilst the 1924 edition offered an overview of the attacks on the classical performances and fleshed out the proposals that had been presented during the previous years. Jannelli and Nicastro’s comments marked a departure from the earlier critiques of Romagnoli as a ‘passéist’. This time, they acknowledged that his scholarship had a modern and Italian character which was distinct from the ‘dusty’ German Hellenism they associated with Wilamowitz.²⁹ Moreover, they applauded Romagnoli’s understanding of Futurism, referring to his review of a Futurist *serata* (evening), a form of performance meant to showcase artistic experimentation and to promote the movement’s aesthetic programme.³⁰ In his review — which was quoted at length by Jannelli and Nicastro — Romagnoli compared the three young poets who recited their poetry amidst the ferocious reactions of the audience to Orpheus fighting against the beasts.³¹ Given his appreciation of youthful creativity, the authors trusted that Romagnoli would be open to their idea of promoting new Sicilian drama and large exhibitions of arts and crafts envisioned as a ‘spring for the arts, the spirit, and modernity’.³²

The edition reiterated the proposals for staging modern plays at the Greek theatre, whilst emphasizing the need for an annual contest for young Sicilian authors. The contest would give young Sicilians the opportunity to channel their creativity, as their works were rejected by publishers who privileged authors with academic credentials. The new type of performance conceived by Jannelli and Nicastro was inspired by local feasts and traditional folk dances and music. Although the details of their proposal remained vague, the performances they had in mind would be characterized by the liveliness and energy of large moving crowds in collective events, something that they deemed possible only in the open air. In line with the anti-classicism of the Futurist movement, Jannelli and Nicastro associated Greek drama with the alleged crisis of contemporary culture; by contrast, folk tradition provided, in their view, the basis for the renewal of Sicily and Italy. This turn to folk art to reinvigorate national artistic production was in keeping with the spirit of popular nationalism which was forming in the interwar period.

The new dramatic work that the Futurists sought to promote was defined as '*moderno, popolare, pittoresco*' ('modern, popular, picturesque/colourful'),³³ capable of expressing the religious and artistic sentiment of the local people and of unleashing the creative forces of contemporary Italy. Echoing Nietzsche's idea that Greek tragedy was rooted in a mythic worldview that defied Christian morality,³⁴ Jannelli and Nicastro maintained that it was impossible to revive the Greek plays in the Christian world because the religious myths of antiquity had lost their grip on the collective consciousness. In a similar manner, the authors rejected efforts to reconstruct ancient texts on the stage through the use of modern staging elements, such as Romagnoli's deployment of modern dance.³⁵ Yet they expressed the conviction that it would be possible to develop a form of contemporary drama that embodied the communal character of Greek tragedy by turning to the traditions and myths that were still alive within Sicilian culture. According to the authors, the performances of new dramatic works of this kind would resemble a religious festival like those of tragedy in classical antiquity. Interestingly, the longing for spirituality that underpinned these plans also characterized the open-air festivals of Greek drama that emerged across Europe in the late nineteenth and early twentieth century.

The authors offered more details about the organizational and practical aspects of performing at the Greek theatre. They backed the plan of an annual contest of new plays by Sicilian authors to coincide with the classical performances from 1925 in line with the proposals presented by Marinetti during his visit to Sicily. Here, however, they deferred to the authority of the Committee over the ancient site, arguing that it would be best suited to organize the contest and to put together a programme comprising modern and ancient plays. The authors stressed the importance of the judges, proposing that the board could consist of two members selected by the Committee alongside Luigi Pirandello, a Sicilian accepted by both classicists and Futurists, and Marinetti himself.³⁶ There is some opportunism in the Futurists' attempt to take advantage of the resources and institutional framework of the classical performances. The authors made no secret that they counted on the support of Gargallo and the local authorities, even suggesting that publicity materials could be combined to save funds. Most importantly, the Futurists sought to use the success of the classical performances to their benefit, to reach out to larger and more international audiences:

[T]he spectators, who rush to Syracuse for Aeschylus or Sophocles, surely would not disdain – attracted by the novelty – to stop and attend the modern drama. Even the foreigners would be interested in a grandiose show with typically Sicilian characters.³⁷

The text ended on a triumphalist note that the modern performances would bring in theatre-goers not attracted by the Greek plays. The authors expressed the belief that in contemporary Italy there were enough people who ‘prefer[red] life to death, the future to the past’.³⁸ In their manifestos, the Futurists downplayed the centrality of Greek antiquity in Sicilian culture and often dismissed the classical performances as a tourist attraction. Their anti-classical fervour was intertwined with an opposition to the commodification of art which typified the historical avant-garde. In that regard, the call to celebrate folk culture was premised upon their two-fold revolt against traditionalism and commercialism.

The Futurists’ willingness to collaborate with the Committee was linked to their aspirations to promote their aesthetic programme as the official style of Italian Fascism. The 1924 edition of *La Balza Futurista* explained why the movement went back to the ideas they presented in 1921. Among the reasons they enumerated, the authors stressed that the advent of the new government had rekindled interest in material and spiritual enhancement.³⁹ It is also clear, however, that the movement’s apprehensions about the diminishing role of Futurism within the new culture of Fascism had been exacerbated by the Regime’s interest in classical art. On the back cover of the issue, the tripartite mission of *La Balza Futurista* was defined as enhancing Sicily, helping Sicilian artists, and ‘bring[ing] Sicilian Fascism back to an anti-passéist and creative conception’.

The proposals concerning the Greek theatre of Syracuse were incorporated in the manifesto that Marinetti submitted to the Fascist government in 1923, advocating for the establishment of a credit bank for artists.⁴⁰ Marinetti’s efforts to garner state support were evident in his emphatic reminder of Futurism’s contribution to Mussolini’s rise to power; during the previous decade, Marinetti argued, the Futurists pioneered the art of militant intervention, they were imprisoned with Mussolini, and participated in the paramilitary associations *Arditi* and the early *Fasci di Combattimento*. He also stressed that, unlike Russian Futurism, the Italian movement was patriotic — though he also noted that Futurism in the Soviet Union had become the official state style. In Marinetti’s view, Futurism was consonant with Fascism’s programme, as testified by a speech where Mussolini had allegedly proclaimed Fascism as a ‘Government of speed’⁴¹; hence, the political and ideological alliances between the two movements should now be complemented by an alignment of their aesthetic visions. Marinetti reiterated his belief that Mussolini had rejuvenated the country and urged him to assist artists in renewing the arts scene. To this end, he put forward a list of recommendations aiming to cultivate the nation’s creativity through encouraging innovation. Among the sentences that Marinetti attributed to Mussolini himself, we read: ‘The Colosseum and the Forum are glories of the past; but we must create the glories for the present, and for tomorrow’.⁴² In this new context, the proposal about the

theatre of Syracuse appears as a direct response to Mussolini's call to veer away from the classical past:

The Theater at Syracuse cannot be used exclusively for the glory of the Greek classics! We demand that, as an alternative to the presentation of classical works, a competition be mounted there to find a colorful modern drama, suitable for open-air production, by a young Sicilian, who will receive his prize and be solemnly crowned in the theater itself.⁴³

A note at the end of the text mentions that Marinetti's recommendations were put forward directly to Mussolini, who approved them in principle.⁴⁴ The epigraph uses a passage from Mussolini's letter expressing his wish that Marinetti would overcome the obstacles posed by the '*misoneisti*' (adversaries of innovation).⁴⁵ Taking the manifesto's timing into account, it is possible to link the reference to Syracuse to Marinetti's attempts to resuscitate Futurism under the new Regime. In this light, the Sicilian controversy can be seen as part of the intensive activities between 1922 and 1924 that aimed to launch a 'second wave' of Futurism following the break with Fascism in 1920.⁴⁶ Perhaps Mussolini's encouragement to include modern plays in the programmes of the Syracusan festival during his 1924 visit echoed the Futurist programme; however, like most of Marinetti's proposals, the idea of staging modern drama at Syracuse was not adopted by the Regime.

Nonetheless, the movement's opposition to the classicism of INDA was not exhausted in the early twenties but stretched into the following decade, as suggested by the sporadic appearance of polemical texts in the press. Worth mentioning is a letter addressed to the director of the newspaper *Futurismo* which was published in said newspaper in 1933. The letter was authored (or at least sent to the newspaper) by Egle Paturzo on behalf of the Futurist movement of Syracuse,⁴⁷ in response to the announcement of *Iphigenia in Tauris* and the *Trachiniae* that INDA planned for that year's festival. The author revolted against INDA and bemoaned the commissioning of artists to stage Greek dramas, which were characterized as 'exhumations', 'ashes', 'funerals', and 'biers'. The director of *Futurismo* shared the indignation of the author; the response to the letter asserted that the classical performances were useless as they neither showed anything new about classical art nor allowed modern poets and artists to express themselves freely. More than being useless, the classical performances, in the director's view, had a pernicious impact on modern culture, perpetuating the admiration of the classics among audiences and forcing on modern artists 'a spiritual atmosphere [which is] false, unreal, anachronistic, and therefore, irreconcilable with our own'. This call for a new type of theatre concluded with the outcry 'Enough with Silvio D'Amico'. The critic D'Amico was a supporter of INDA's work, but the link between

him and the classical performances indicates that for the Futurists, Greek drama was associated with the bourgeois culture they opposed. Contrary to this view, Mussolini saw the classical performances as an ideal alternative to the bourgeois theatre that he, too, rejected.⁴⁸

The letter and the response published in *Futurismo* are of particular interest because they shed light on the conflict between the Futurists and INDA. The Futurists viewed the Classicists at Syracuse as key rivals in creating new theatrical forms under Fascism. Although the Futurists dismissed the stagings of Greek drama as an undertaking of a few classical enthusiasts, what they took issue with was INDA's status as an official institution. Considering that INDA had already been made a national institute by 1925, this belated reaction must have been prompted by its 'fascistization' in the thirties, following the appointment of Biagio Pace as president, with whom the Regime replaced Gargallo.⁴⁹ The exchange between Paturzo and the director reveals that the Futurists' hostility to INDA emanated from their aspirations to create a new form of theatre that could serve Fascism's programme of cultural renewal. Paturzo was preoccupied with the question of what kind of art could give form to the 'fascist verb "svecchiare"' (modernize). Reiterating the earlier proclamations by the Sicilian circle, the director stressed that Futurism embraced the concept of performing in the open air but would rather develop grandiose modern installations suited for bold dramatic conceptions, based on Marinetti's idea of Total Theatre, which will be discussed later.

Most of the Futurist texts about the theatre of Syracuse built upon the proposals presented in the second manifesto of 1921. Yet in 1940 the first manifesto resurfaced when its original authors sent it to the *Agenzia Letteraria Artistica* (Literary Artistic Agency) with the request to disseminate it.⁵⁰ The manifesto was accompanied by a letter dated 25 November and the note that it was unconditionally approved by Marinetti. The old controversy with the 'inattuali' ('outdated') Classicists of INDA resurfaced, but this time the animosity of the Futurists was not directed at the classical performances or the Hellenic past but to the modern Greeks: the letter quoted Il Duce's statement that the Greeks hated Italy more than any other nation. What made the senders of the letter feel vindicated about their initial attack on the classical performances at Syracuse in this instance was Greece's successful counterattack against Mussolini's invading forces in October 1940.

As these controversies demonstrate, the radical ideas of the artistic vanguard were inextricably linked to historical, ideological, and political developments. The language deployed in the different versions of the manifestos published by the Futurists in Sicily speaks to the convergence between artistic and political

radicalism around the rise of Fascism. In the first manifesto of 1921, the Syracusan councillors were described as ‘*funghi di muffa sopra un verde tronco*’ (‘mouldy fungi on a green truck’) who transported ‘*cose puzzolenti*’ (‘smelly things’) — the classical performances — into a city admired for its cleanliness.⁵¹ When referring to classical antiquity, the Futurist texts abound with metaphors of putrefaction, which are suggestive of the notions of cultural hygiene widely adopted within fascist discourses. Moreover, their pledge to contribute to Sicily’s rejuvenation echoed the myths of national rebirth that inspired fascist movements across Europe. What becomes clear by looking at the Futurist programmes of cultural renewal is that Fascism was not the first movement that sought to lift Italy out of stagnation; similar ideas were prevalent within the artistic vanguard, but were also espoused by the pioneers of the classical performances at Syracuse. The open air emerged as the ideal setting for new theatrical forms that could remedy the crisis of bourgeois theatre and culture.

Utopian theatrical visions

While the Syracusan Committee was working to revive Greek drama in the open air, the exponents of Futurism concentrated their efforts on devising new theatrical forms which had arguably little in common with ancient theatre. As an avant-garde movement, Futurism rejected both highbrow and popular theatre and strove to create unfamiliar forms, distinguished by their ability to surprise the spectator. In addition to breaking away from the dramatic canon, these forms were focused on the performance as a live event rather than on the text. One of the early forms developed along these lines was that of the *Teatro di Varietà* (Variety Theatre), a synthesis of lowbrow spectacles fused with the technological possibilities of film. The Variety Theatre claimed a total liberation from tradition, renouncing ‘the Solemn, the Sacred, the Serious, and the Sublime in Art with a capital A’.⁵² The manifesto for the Variety Theatre published in 1913 called for condensed versions of dramatic works, including Greek tragedies, interspersed with comedic and farcical effects. The manifesto attacked naturalist drama as well as historical plays which were dismissed as sheer ‘pastiche or plagiarism’.⁵³ For the Futurists, the sequential logic of the dramatic play was not only incompatible with the dynamism of the modern era but also associated with the formulas of psychological theatre which they rejected. Despite the manifesto’s assault on Greek tragedy,⁵⁴ Futurism’s call for a theatre that veered away from psychological drama provided a significant point of convergence with the revival of Greek theatre. This convergence can be seen in a later manifesto, where Marinetti remarks that Gabriele D’Annunzio’s theatre would be Futurist if it were not ridden with psychology and philosophy.⁵⁵ Given that D’Annunzio was one of the key

forces behind the revival of tragedy in the open air, this acknowledged affinity with his work attests to a latent commonality between Futurist theatre and classical performances.

Another type of spectacle that grew out of Futurist experimentations was *Teatro Sintetico* (Synthetic Theatre),⁵⁶ a type of minidrama operating through concentrated action and pithy dialogue. The model of Synthetic Theatre opposed brevity and simultaneity to the prolixity and causality of traditional drama, whilst also relying on improvisation and sensory effects. *Teatro della Sorpresa* (Theatre of Surprise), similar to Synthetic Theatre, rejected the norms of dramatic writing in favour of mixing different types of performance, from theatre to poetry, music, and dance.⁵⁷ Once again, performance was regarded as a medium that had the power to galvanize the crowd through a combination of provocative situations, dynamic recitations, living newspapers, physical acts, and elements of popular spectacle such as acrobats, magicians, and jugglers. The manifesto (signed, among others, by Jannelli) indicates that this turn to popular spectacles was conceptualized in terms of a genuine theatricality, in contrast to the domination of drama. In that regard, the proposals to stage Sicilian puppet theatre or plays based on folk rites at the ancient theatre of Syracuse presented by the Futurists in Sicily were consistent with their vision of a dynamic spectacle pitted against a static classical tradition.

The types of theatre conceived by the Futurists necessitated new theatrical spaces that could generate a different relationship with the audience. To this end, the Futurists dispensed with the frontal, proscenium arch structure and sought to create spatial arrangements that would allow them to tap into the energy of the audience. The spaces they envisioned bore the discernible influence of the Total Theatre designed by Walter Gropius of the Bauhaus school for Erwin Piscator's Epic Theatre.⁵⁸ Gropius's Total Theatre was an attempt to merge the circus arena, the Greek amphitheatre, and the contemporary back stage which is separated from the auditorium. In a similar fashion, the version of the Total Theatre presented by the Futurists in 1933 consisted of a large circular stage divided into smaller stages to allow for several acts and lines of action to unfold simultaneously. Despite their discrepancies, the descriptions in the published text and the drawings indicate a venue of grand proportions. Like Gropius' model, the Futurist Total Theatre deployed the latest technological advancements but at the same time harkened back to the open theatres of antiquity. The Futurists do not acknowledge debts to Gropius or mention Greek theatre, yet, whether acknowledged or not, the efforts of the avant-garde to dispense with the conventions of bourgeois theatre led back to Greek theatre as a space that could accommodate the masses — imagined as the proletariat by Piscator or a patriotic crowd by the Futurists. To a large extent, these visions reached back to Greek

theatre via the Wagnerian *Gesamtkunstwerk*. Performance in the Futurist Total Theatre combined prose, music, visuals, and sensory effects in an art form that ‘synthesize[d] the world’.⁵⁹ This reinvention of theatre as a synthesis of the arts was associated with the return to the open air as well as with the form of Greek tragedy. Interest in Greek tragedy as a synthesis of theatre, dance, and music was at the heart of the ancient drama festivals across Europe; the festival of Syracuse was also conceptualized by its founders as a new Bayreuth.⁶⁰

Considering these underlying affinities between the artistic vanguard and the project of reviving Greek tragedy, it comes as little surprise that the bulletin of the Syracusan Committee published in 1928 included an article by the Futurist artist, filmmaker, and theorist Anton Giulio Bragaglia on the advantages of the open air for recovering a true sense of theatricality.⁶¹ Bragaglia rejected the proposals of the Sicilian Futurists to create a modern drama drawing on folk traditions, arguing that the renewal of the dramatic art could not rely on a single form. Equally, he dismissed the classical performances as ‘*rimasticazioni*’ (‘rehashings’) of ancient plays which appealed only to decadent intellectuals and tourists. The editors of the bulletin added a note stating their disagreement with the author, but they nonetheless acknowledged there were a few points of convergence. Interestingly, they underscored the value of debating all opinions in the arts, as had recently been affirmed by the head of the government. In this spirit, they deemed it appropriate to publish even ‘extremist’ theories.

The Total Theatre developed by the Futurists was, by and large, congruent with Fascism’s ideas for theatrical renewal. At the same time, however, the Futurist experimentations with dramaturgical models and theatrical formats could not be fully reconciled with the theatre for the people promoted by Mussolini. The efforts to create forms of popular theatre are discussed in an article by philosopher and academic Francesco Orestano, who was involved in both Futurist and Fascist aesthetic debates. Orestano mentioned the model for the Theatre of the Masses which was presented by Gaetano Ciocca at the Volta conference in 1934⁶² following Mussolini’s call for a theatre of 15,000 or 20,000 spectators.⁶³ It is noteworthy that Orestano linked the visions of popular theatre to the classical performances at Syracuse. However, he also articulated his scepticism towards mass spectacles which, in his view, addressed simple audiences as they could express intense passions but not intricate psychological situations or characters; instead he defended the usefulness of intimate theatrical settings which could serve psychological drama as well as Marinetti’s avant-garde visions.⁶⁴

Under Mussolini’s Regime, Marinetti sought to secure funding to establish a theatrical institution where members of the movement could put their revolutionary ideas into practice. Whilst Mussolini showed some interest in this

proposal, the plans were turned down by the government as financially unfeasible.⁶⁵ On the other hand, the consolidation of INDA enhanced the status of the Syracuse festival and expanded the classical performances to other ancient theatres and archaeological sites in Italy. It is possible to deduce that, unlike the ambitious visions of the artistic vanguard, the classical performances provided a suitable (and perhaps less costly) model for creating a new form of popular theatre. However, it would be wrong to interpret this support for INDA as a turn to traditionalism after the revolutionary phase of Italian Fascism: in fact, Futurist-inspired performances continued to receive state support, as demonstrated by the grand-scale performance *18BL* which took place on the left bank of the Arno in Florence in 1934. The one-off show for 20,000 spectators put together by the filmmaker Alessandro Blasetti was conceived as a realization of Mussolini's Theatre of the Masses. The use of searchlights and loudspeakers as well as motor vehicles, artillery, and aeroplanes were reminiscent of the Futurist Theatre of the Skies.⁶⁶ The machine protagonist, the 18BL FIAT truck, symbolizing Italy, attested to the elevation of technology to a mythical status. Although the spectacle was carefully planned and enjoyed the support of the Regime, it went down as a failed experiment: according to Jeffrey Schnapp's account, the vastness of the space diminished the possibility of immersion in the spectacle, while an overreliance on technology combined with a series of technical failures alienated the spectators.⁶⁷

Whereas several modernist movements looked backwards to arrive at new forms, Futurism strove to demolish the past and recreate the world from first principles. The classical performances at Syracuse might have differed from the theatrical experimentations of Futurism, but they were underpinned by the same vision: at the root of both lay the desire to purge the world and imbue modernity with a sense of renewed spirituality. As this analysis of Futurist theatres and classical performances demonstrates, the utopian visions of artistic modernism not only intersected but also fed into Fascism's plans for reforming culture. In this respect, the battle that the Futurists undertook against the Greek theatre at Syracuse was not a clash between modernism and classicism but rather between two competing models for renewing culture under Mussolini. To put it in Marinetti's terms,⁶⁸ the aesthetic ideal embodied in the classical performances was not akin to the Victory of Samothrace, which he famously juxtaposed to the beauty of the racing car; surrounded by automobiles, locomotives, and electric lights, the Greek theatre of Syracuse offered an ideal site for fusing past and present into the artwork of the future.

Fascism: Futurist or Classicist?

Despite Mussolini's acknowledged debts to Futurism as the precursor of the Fascist revolution,⁶⁹ Futurism was never decreed as the official style of Italian Fascism. The marginalization of Futurism has been attributed to its anarchistic tendencies being at odds with the hierarchical order upon which Mussolini's state was built. According to Günter Berghaus:

The first years of Mussolini's reign were characterized by a 'return to order' in artistic matters too. Futurism could sometimes play a useful role in propagating the government's modernist image, but it was never allowed to occupy more than a marginal position in the cultural hierarchy.⁷⁰

For Berghaus, the rift with Futurism signalled the end of the Fascist revolution and the consolidation of a new political order.⁷¹ However, it is important to stress that unlike Nazism, Italian Fascism did not suppress the artistic avant-garde. Rather than privileging academicism over modernist innovation, it encouraged the co-existence of competing movements and accommodated heterogenous styles blending classicism and modernism.⁷² On the other hand, there was definitely a rift between Futurism's aesthetic and political visions and the cult of *romanità* promoted by Fascism. Even though Marinetti supported Italy's imperialist expansion, his version of the Italian empire was not predicated upon the grandeur of ancient Rome. Notably, for him the invocation of Rome constituted a form of plagiarism⁷³ — a term he often used to refer to the art that imitated past traditions. As Andrew Hewitt remarks, 'Marinetti resorted to an ultimately *modernist* insistence on originality and innovation in his attack on imperialist plagiarism'.⁷⁴

The question as to whether Fascism was Classicist or Futurist, which has preoccupied discussions within classical reception studies, can be traced all the way back to contemporary debates that grappled with Fascism's apparent contradictions. These debates around Fascism's relationship with Futurism are doubly illuminating: firstly, they put Fascism's complex relationship with modernism and classicism in historical perspective by revealing how it was perceived and analysed at the beginning of *ventennio*; secondly — and most importantly — they point to uses of the notion of classicism to understand Fascism as a political and cultural phenomenon.

In July 1923, Giuseppe Prezolini published an article under the title 'Futurism and Fascism', denying any intellectual kinship between the two movements.⁷⁵ Prezolini was the editor of the Florence-based literary magazine *La Voce* (The

Voice) which had united diverse currents of the avant-garde against Futurism. The rivalry between *La Voce* and Futurism dated back to 1909, but it intensified as they both fought for prominence within Fascist culture. The clear-cut divide between Futurism and Fascism proposed by Prezolini should be understood as an attempt to decouple these two movements and to emphasize the leading role of the *Vociani* in renewing art and culture.⁷⁶ In Prezolini's view, Fascism had undoubtedly adopted Futurist principles such the exaltation of speed and violence and the desire to dominate the crowds. Notably, Prezolini referred to the 1923 manifesto that Marinetti addressed to the Fascist government, arguing that despite their affinities and historical alliances, Futurism and Fascism had different intellectual roots. Prezolini's attempt to separate Fascism from Futurism was based on the premise that the two movements represented a radically different stance towards tradition. The anti-classical posture of Futurism articulated in its assault on museums was contrasted in the article with Fascism's fondness for 'using the most authentic of Roman ruins as the background to its military reviews'.⁷⁷ In Prezolini's view, the invocations of classical Rome and the promotion of Latin in education (with the 1923 school reform by the Minister of Education Giovanni Gentile) demonstrated Fascism's adherence to tradition. Prezolini uses the notion of the 'classical' to refer not only to the ancient past, but as a category associated with certain scholarly and literary merits — namely discipline, rigour, and authority — as well as traditional moral and national values. Within this framework, he deems the revolutionary impetus of Futurism incompatible with Fascism's hankering for the classical ideal.

The arguments about Fascist classicism advanced by Prezolini did not go uncontested. In a riposte that appeared in the press after the publication of his article, an author writing under the name Landoti argued that although Fascism invoked the classical, it lacked the mental order and internal equilibrium which were the preconditions of classicism.⁷⁸ In a similar fashion, the author viewed Futurism as a movement that pursued the new and incorporated modernist values but regressed into the past. Consequently, the most prominent commonality between Futurism and Fascism was their tendency to collapse everything into disorder, despite their different programmes, driving forces, and inherent strengths. For the author, there was no contradiction in their different manifestations, such as the destruction of the museums on the one hand, and Mussolini's speeches in front of the ruins of the Roman Forum on the other, as the two movements shared the 'same spiritual background'. Landoti maintained that Fascism had little to do with the classical properties, defined as 'orderly, rhythmical, serene, strong, clear, and sure', and attributed the vulgar and disorderly aspects of Fascism not to D'Annunzio but to Futurism, describing Fascism as 'nationalist Futurism'. In line with Mussolini's words, the article

concluded that 'Fascism is Futurism rising into power' and went as far as to suggest that under Mussolini, Italy had acquired a Futurist government.

My intention is not to determine which of the two authors is more accurate in their appraisal of Fascism, but to demonstrate that the contradictory nature of Fascist modernism preoccupied intellectuals in the early years of the *ventennio*. To a great extent, the contradiction arose from the glorification of the classical combined with the aspiration to radically transform culture which Fascism shared with the artistic avant-garde. Berghaus opposes the claims that Fascism was devoid of culture and argues that Mussolini's state returned to order after 1925, following the consolidation of the dictatorship. The pursuit of order can be witnessed in a series of actions meant to demonstrate the Regime's investment in the arts, such as the establishment of the *Istituto Nazionale di Cultura Fascista* (National Institute of Fascist Culture),⁷⁹ the national encyclopaedia, and the gradual 'fascistization' of cultural institutions.⁸⁰ Moreover, according to Berghaus, the turn to the past as seen in the cult of *romanità* or the cultural movement of the *strapaese* (super-country) crafted a new image of Fascism. It can be argued that the Hellenic modernism of the Syracusan festival served a similar purpose. Therefore, the consolidation of INDA should be seen as directly related to these efforts to improve the Regime's image. This turn to the classical past does not mean, however, that Italian Fascism relinquished the totalising visions of Futurism: this was not a 'combination of revolutionary rhetoric and conservative practice'⁸¹ in a tactical or utilitarian sense, as Berghaus has it, but a fusion of classicism with a futurist thrust which was core to Fascism's revolutionary ideology.

Emilio Gentile links the invocations of Rome with the efforts of the Regime to constitute a modern mythology. As he points out, Roman history provided the 'arsenal from which to draw myths of mobilization and legitimization for political action'.⁸² The references to antiquity did not represent a nostalgic recourse to the past but contributed to constructing the foundational myth for Italy's new beginning. Recent studies have shown that the cult of *romanità* promoted by Italian Fascism was pivotal to its vision of a renewed modernity.⁸³ Greek antiquity was not excluded from this vision. Since their inception, the classical performances at Syracuse had expressed a Sicilian sense of cosmopolitanism combined with the nationalist spirit of the early twentieth century.⁸⁴ But their treatment of Greek theatre as a new spiritual experience served Fascism's aspirations to renew culture. Like Futurism, Italian Fascism departed from the idea of a venerated tradition, but instead of abandoning classical antiquity altogether, it reclaimed it and transformed it into a modern national mythology. In 1926 journalist Gesualdo Manzella Frontini argued that the art of the state could not be Futurist and proclaimed that:

This new art must be classical [...], balanced, and rooted in tradition and the soil of the earth, in order to nourish the eternal life stream of the immortal race, always new and always renewing itself.⁸⁵

However, far from being incompatible with Futurism, the turn to classical tradition provided Fascism with an alternative — and perhaps a more effective — way of giving concrete form to the ideas that fuelled the radical visions of Futurism. Ultimately, the destruction of the past promulgated by Futurism and the rediscovery of classical Greece since the late nineteenth century both signalled an attempt to remedy the crisis of modernity and recreate the world. Like other modernist movements, Italian Fascism treated classical art as a vehicle to heal a decaying culture. In analysing the relationships between Futurism and Fascism, Gentile argues that both movements sought to synthesize a modern national mythology.⁸⁶ Yet there is a key difference in their myth-making processes: Futurism strove to obliterate the past and accord the modern age the mythic status of the classical; Fascism, on the other hand, did not treat classical antiquity as a decaying tradition but claimed it as a living force that could reinvigorate the present and provide the materials for (re)building the future. Therefore, Fascism's turn to the classical past should not be understood as a *rappel à l'ordre* but as a reinvention of the classical through modernist aesthetics and, at the same time, an attempt to recast modernism in classical form.

Conclusion

Despite the stark differences between Futurist theatres and classical performances, closer scrutiny suggests that the utopian visions they served were in accord. Roger Griffin observes that modernist movements sought to build their utopias using 'healthy' elements of the past rather than seeking to create them from scratch like Italian Futurism.⁸⁷ In this respect, the classical performances at the Greek Theatre of Syracuse can be understood as representing a desire to revitalize Hellenic traditions and imbue contemporary theatre with renewed spiritual energy. On the other hand, the provocative tactics and intense sensory effects deployed in Futurist theatres can be directly linked to the movement's belief in the purging effect of violence and the calls to sanitize culture from what its exponents saw as the vestiges of a decaying tradition. However, in both cases, theatre assumed a therapeutic function as a remedy to the discontents of the modern world, and offered the means to transform it.

The classical performances at Syracuse attest to the appeal that the rediscovery of Greece held over the aesthetic and political movements of the interwar period as a

response to a cultural crisis. Under Mussolini, Hellenic modernism complemented the cult of *romanità* in forging a sense of rootedness within a rapidly changing historical landscape. This turn to the past was not motivated by the need to connect with great ancestors, but rather represented a fusion of antiquity and modernity that enabled Fascism to manufacture a new chronopolitical reality. Grounded in a synergy between classicism and modernism, the performances of Greek drama responded to the desire to break with dominant artistic modes and recreate culture itself. Given that the same desire drove the cultural reforms implemented by Italian Fascism, it comes as no surprise that Mussolini took interest in the Syracuse festival. As this analysis has shown, despite decrying the revival of Greek theatre at Syracuse as ‘passéist’, the Futurists were also cognizant of the modernist character of the classical performances. Their persistent reactions demonstrated that they perceived INDA as a major rival both in securing state support and in creating the new types of theatre envisioned by Italian Fascism.

In the epilogue to his famous essay on the artwork in the age of mechanical reproduction, Walter Benjamin links Marinetti’s exaltation of the new kind of warfare that was begotten by industrial progress to Fascism’s ability to experience total destruction as the ultimate artwork.⁸⁸ The self-destructive tendencies within Futurism and Fascism account for the fact that the Futurist side of Fascism did not outlive WW2. By contrast, the performances of Greek drama at Syracuse and other ancient sites, vouchsafed under the category of the ‘classical’, carried on into the post-war period and, to a significant degree, provided a reference point for ancient drama festivals in the open air. This is not to say that the productions of Greek drama were invariably shaped by Fascist aesthetics, but rather that the perception of the classics as floating above historical conjuncture often prevented the interrogation of the institutional and aesthetic continuities with fascist cultures. Such an interrogation starts by examining not only fascism’s dialogue with Greco-Roman traditions but also the role of the classical ideals that furnished the means to realize the transformative visions of modernism.

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NOTES ON CONTRIBUTOR

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- 1 'Le accoglienze di Siracusa e la partenza sulla "Dante"', *Corriere Mercantile*, Genoa, 14 May 1924 and 'L'ultima giornata siciliana del Presidente del Consiglio', *Ordine*, Ancona, 14 May 1924 in AFI (Archivio Fondazione INDA) Rassegna Stampa 1924. The scheduled visits to Taormina and Messina were cancelled as Mussolini had to attend the *Conferenza per l'emigrazione* (Conference for Emigration). See 'L'on. Mussolini lascia la Sicilia dopo un viaggio trionfale', *Gazzetta dell'Emilia*, Modena, 14 May 1924 in AFI Rassegna Stampa 1924.
- 2 The visit to Mussolini occurred on 17 January 1924. Apart from Gargallo, the delegation consisted of Francesco Mauceri, Francesco Boccadifuoco, Ugo Bonanno, Costante Bongiovanni, Monteneri, Leone Leone, and Biagio Pace. Pace was a professor of archaeology and member of the Fascist party and was later elected member of the Chamber of Deputies for Sicily. He was appointed president of INDA in 1929 after Gargallo's removal from the role. The information about this visit was published in the Committee's bulletin *Rappresentazioni Classiche al Teatro Greco di Siracusa: Bollettino del Comitato* 3 (January–February 1924), 18. See also 'Il Presidente del Consiglio assisterà alle rappresentazioni classiche di Siracusa', *Giornale dell'Isola*, Catania, 19 January 1924 in AFI Rassegna Stampa 1924.
- 3 'Il viaggio dell'on. Mussolini in Sicilia: Il programma e gli scopi della visita', *Resto del Carlino della Sera*, Bologna, 25 April 1924 in AFI Rassegna Stampa 1924.
- 4 Mussolini's pledge regarding Sicily was made in a speech delivered in Palermo, reported in *La Fiamma*, 11 May 1924, 1. The information is provided in Reece (1973: 267–8). On the Sicilian economy under Fascism, see Smith (1968). On Fascism's presence in Sicily and the fight with the mafia, see Duggan (1989).
- 5 See the newspaper article cited in footnote 3. Also 'Cronaca siracusana: L'on. Mussolini in Sicilia', *Corriere di Sicilia*, Catania, 24 April 1924 in AFI Rassegna Stampa 1924.
- 6 'Cronaca di Siracusa: Programma visita S.E. Mussolini', *Giornale dell'Isola*, Catania, 13 May 1924 in AFI Rassegna Stampa 1924.
- 7 The telegram was sent through Leone Leone and stated Mussolini's firm intention to attend the classical performances. See 'L'on. Mussolini alle rappresentazioni classiche di Siracusa', *Idea Nazionale*, Rome, 23 January 1924 in AFI Rassegna Stampa 1924.
- 8 'Rombanti automobili'. This is mentioned in the newspaper article 'L'on. Mussolini a Siracusa', *Corriere di Sicilia*, Catania, 13 May 1924 in AFI Rassegna Stampa 1924.
- 9 'Il messaggio di Mussolini ai siciliani: L'entusiasmo del Presidente per lo spettacolo di

- Siracusa', *Gazzetta del Popolo*, Turin, 15 May 1924 in AFI Rassegna Stampa 1924.
- 10 Gentile (1996: 87).
- 11 On the *Carri di Tespi*, see Corsi (1939: 263–88). Thompson (1996: 106–10) and Schnapp (1996: 13–30) link this new type of touring playhouse to the Regime's promotion of open-air popular forms of theatre.
- 12 'Mussolini al Teatro Greco di Siracusa: Anche le tragedie moderne?', *Giornale d'Italia*, Rome, 18 May 1924 in AFI Rassegna Stampa 1924. See also his conversation with Gargallo discussed in the introduction of this issue.
- 13 The Roman plays staged by INDA were Plautus' *Menaechmi* and *Aulularia* at the Roman theatre of Ostia in 1938. The translation and artistic direction were by Luigi Chiarelli.
- 14 Jannelli et al. (1921). The signatories were Guglielmo Jannelli, Luciano Nicastro, Vann'Antò (Giovanni Antonio Di Giacomo), Francesco Carrozza, and Aldo Raciti. The manifesto was published in *Cronache d'Attualità* in May 1921. Berghaus (1998: 357–9) offers a brief discussion of the Futurists' opposition to the classical performances. Sammartano (2003) understands their assault on Greek theatre in the context of the Italian avant-garde's efforts to revitalize culture. In Sammartano's view, the visions of the avant-garde were thwarted by the encounter between Futurism and Fascism which put an end to the movement's artistic creativity. His article, however, does not address the connections between classicism and Fascism. Treu (2006) argues that the satirical tone and Aristophanic references in the manifesto were targeted at Romagnoli, who was planning to stage Aristophanes and satyr drama at Syracuse.
- 15 Aeschylus (2009). *Lib.* 886. The translations from the Italian are mine unless otherwise stated. Selected words and phrases are quoted in Italian to offer the reader more unmediated access to the original.
- 16 The authors must be referring to the Futurist Synthetic Theatre already introduced in 1915 by Marinetti, Emilio Settimelli, and Bruno Corra. The term 'Synthetic Theatre' has been translated as 'Theatre of Essential Brevity', see Marinetti (2006, originally 1915: 200–7).
- 17 Marinetti (2006, originally 1909: 14): '[W]e wish to free our country from the stinking canker of its professors, archaeologists, tour guides, and antiquarians'.
- 18 Carrozza (1922).
- 19 The account of the events and the second manifesto can be found in Carrozza (1922) as well as in the 1924 edition of *La Balza Futurista*. Marinetti's talk must have provided the basis of the second manifesto.
- 20 Berghaus (1996: 73–5) highlights the discrepancies between Marinetti's assertions that

the intervention at the Teatro dal Verme in Milan in 1914 converted spectators to Futurism and the report of the Prefect of Milan to the Public Security Office in Rome, which spoke of an event carried out by a few individuals who found no support in the audience, and did not make the press.

- 21 Karavia ([1921](#)).
- 22 Jannelli et al. ([1921](#)) and republished in Jannelli and Nicastro ([1924](#): 17–19).
- 23 The text was signed by Guglielmo Jannelli, Luciano Nicastro, and Francesco Carrozza for Messina; Mario Shrapnel, Giacomo Etna, and S. Lo Presti for Catania; Drago, Calderone, Perroni, and Attardi for Palermo; F. Sortino and B. Cimino for Girgenti and Caltanissetta; A. Fiandaca for Trapani; and Aldo Raciti and Vann’Antò for Syracuse.
- 24 In a similar manner, Carrozza ([1922](#)) eloquently argued that modern performances would allow foreign visitors, besides praising the beauty of the skies, to understand and admire the soul of the locals.
- 25 Jannelli et al. ([1921](#)).
- 26 Jannelli et al. ([1921](#)).
- 27 Miniotti ([2015](#): 50–1).
- 28 Vicre ([1922](#)).
- 29 Jannelli and Nicastro ([1924](#): 6). Parts of Jannelli and Nicastro’s text were published in the newspaper article ‘I futuristi e il Teatro Greco di Siracusa: A proposito delle rappresentazioni classiche’, *Gazzetta di Messina*, Messina, 2 May 1924 in AFI Rassegna Stampa 1924.
- 30 On the Futurist *serata*, see Berghaus ([1998](#): 85–155) and ([2005](#): 109–11).
- 31 Romagnoli cited in Jannelli and Nicastro ([1924](#): 6–8).
- 32 Jannelli and Nicastro ([1924](#): 9).
- 33 Jannelli and Nicastro ([1924](#): 13).
- 34 Nietzsche ([2008](#), originally 1872).
- 35 Jannelli and Nicastro ([1924](#): 22) mentioned the Committee’s collaboration with the Braun Sisters, students of Émile Jaques-Dalcroze and instructors of eurhythmics. On the use of eurhythmics in INDA’s productions of Greek drama, see Ioannidou (forthcoming [2024](#)).
- 36 Jannelli and Nicastro ([1924](#): 32).

- 37 Jannelli and Nicastro ([1924](#): 33).
- 38 Jannelli and Nicastro ([1924](#): 35).
- 39 Jannelli and Nicastro ([1924](#): 11).
- 40 Marinetti ([2006](#), originally 1923: 357–63). There are multiple versions of this manifesto dating back to 1919. The later versions included a passage from Mussolini’s letter to Marinetti in the epigraph. The passages quoted here follow Doug Thompson’s translation in Marinetti ([2006](#)).
- 41 Mussolini quoted in Marinetti ([2006](#), originally 1923: 358).
- 42 Mussolini quoted in Marinetti ([2006](#), originally 1923: 358).
- 43 Marinetti ([2006](#), originally 1923: 359). The text attributes the proposal about Syracuse to specific artists, including the instigators of the Sicilian controversy in 1921 as well as the theatrical innovators Enrico Prampolini, Fortunato Depero, and Mario Cangiullo.
- 44 Mussolini’s epigraph in Marinetti ([1923](#)).
- 45 Thompson’s translation of ‘*misoneisti*’ is ‘stick-in-the-muds’. Marinetti ([2006](#), originally 1923: 363).
- 46 Berghaus ([1996](#): 221).
- 47 Velocizzatore ([1933](#)). No information about Paturzo is available in the *Dizionario biografico degli Italiani* ([2017](#)).
- 48 See Mussolini’s address to the Italian authors discussed in the introduction to this issue.
- 49 On the removal of Gargallo and Romagnoli, see Troiani in this issue.
- 50 AFI Rassegna Stampa 1940.
- 51 Jannelli et al. ([1921](#)).
- 52 Marinetti ([2006](#), originally 1913: 189).
- 53 Marinetti ([2006](#), originally 1913: 185).
- 54 Marinetti ([2006](#), originally 1913: 190): ‘So we have to fight against and eliminate Parisian-style *revues*, which are as stupid and tedious as Greek tragedy, with their masters of ceremonies of both sexes taking on the role of the ancient chorus [...]’.
- 55 Marinetti ([2006](#), originally 1924: 388).
- 56 Marinetti in Rainey et al. ([2009](#): 204–9). The manifesto appeared in 1919 and was signed

- by Marinetti, Emilio Settimelli, and Bruno Corra.
- 57 Marinetti in Rainey et al. (2009: 270–2).
- 58 Gropius (1961: 7–14). On the different versions of Total Theatre designed in the twenties, see Berghaus (2005: 221–2). On the similarities between Gropius’s Total Theatre and Gaetano Ciocca’s Theatre of the Twenty Thousand, see Fried (2014: 181–91) and the introduction to this issue. On the Futurist Total Theatre, see Marinetti (2006: 400–7).
- 59 Marinetti (2006, originally 1933: 405).
- 60 On the impact of Bayreuth as a reference point for theatre festivals in open air, see Michelakis (2010).
- 61 Bragaglia (1928).
- 62 About the Volta conference, see introduction to this issue. Also Fried (2014).
- 63 Orestano probably means Mussolini’s speech on the occasion of the fiftieth anniversary of the *Società Italiana degli Autori ed Editori* (Italian Society of Authors and Editors, S.I.A.E.) at the Argentina Theatre in Rome in 1933.
- 64 Orestano (1936). A condensed version of this text was published in *Gazzetta del Popolo*, Turin, 14 May 1936 in AFI Rassengna Stampa 1936.
- 65 See Berghaus’s note to the text ‘Total Theatre: Its Architecture and Technology’ in Marinetti (2006: 506).
- 66 Marinetti (2006, originally 1932: 408–9).
- 67 On the reception of *18BL*, see Schnapp (1996: 77–82).
- 68 Marinetti in Rainey et al. (2009, originally 1909: 51): ‘A racing car with a hood that glistens with large pipes resembling a serpent with explosive breath ... a roaring automobile that seems to ride on grapeshot – that is more beautiful than the *Victory of Samothrace*’.
- 69 Mussolini cited in De Bagnac (2011: 425): ‘I now formally declare that without Futurism there would never have been a fascist revolution’. Cf. Marinetti’s (2006: 242) statement from an interview in 1915: ‘[T]here is within him [Mussolini] a more personal Futurism, a tendency which is more deeply rooted. And with this, I am referring to his repeatedly expressed hatred for everything that is outmoded in Italy and which, in his view, should have been eclipsed a long time ago.’
- 70 Berghaus (1998: 334). See also Falasca-Zamponi (1996) on Futurism’s abandonment of politics and retreat into the aesthetic sphere after Mussolini’s rise to power.
- 71 Berghaus (1998: 335–8). Erika Fischer-Lichte (2005) advances a similar understanding of

the Soviet mass spectacles and the Nazi genre of *Thingspiel*, which both drew on practices of the theatrical avant-garde. Fischer-Lichte argues that these spectacles were the product of the revolutionary period and waned after the establishment of a new order.

- 72 See Falasca-Zamponi's afterword to this issue.
- 73 Marinetti cited in Hewitt (1992: 48).
- 74 Hewitt (1992: 49) (original emphasis).
- 75 Prezzolini (1923).
- 76 On the politics of *La Voce*, see Gentile (2003: 27–40).
- 77 Prezzolini in Rainey et al. (2009, originally 1923: 276).
- 78 Landoti (1923).
- 79 The institute was originally named *Istituto Nazionale Fascista di Cultura* (National Fascist Institute of Culture).
- 80 Berghaus (1996: 227). On the fascistisation of theatre, see Thompson (1996).
- 81 Berghaus (1996: 227).
- 82 Gentile (2003: 60).
- 83 Nelis (2007) and (2014).
- 84 On the festival's beginnings and its Syracusan and Sicilian identity, see Di Martino (2019).
- 85 Frontini quoted in Berghaus (1996: 236).
- 86 Gentile (2003: 41–75).
- 87 Griffin (2007: 68).
- 88 Benjamin (1969, originally 1935: 241–2).

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